Some days, Joan would organize a minibus and we'd all head off down to Walthamstow baths. There was also a skate ramp by the side of the hut. I suppose my mum knows now that some of my cuts and bruises were from skateboarding, even though I wasn't allowed on a skateboard back then. The one bad knock I got happened one evening when I fell getting our ball back from the paddling pool after it had been closed up for the night. Joan was still there and she phoned home to tell my parents how I'd got the cut on my head. For about six or seven years, into my early teens, it was a whole world in that park. All those facilities have gone now. It's a shame. Times change and some kids started messing the place up until it had to be closed down.

My very first close friend was a boy called John Brown who lived just up the road. John and I went through both primary and secondary school together. He wasn't really a soccer player so, when I couldn't talk him into a kickabout over at the park, we'd play Lego or, later, Gameboy round at one of our houses, or ride our bikes or rollerskate up and down our road. Later on, when I started playing for Ridgeway Rovers, John used to come along to some of our games even though he didn't play. A few of us, especially me and another Ridgeway boy named Nicky Lockwood, were always up for the movies and John used to come too; I remember Mum would drop us off at the cinema over in Walthamstow. When we were little, John Brown and I were best mates but I suppose my soccer took me in a very different direction. John went off and became a baker after we both left school.

Lucky for me, they loved their soccer at my first school, Chase Lane Primary. I can still remember Mr McGhee, the teacher who used to coach us: a Scotsman and passionate with it, a bit like Alex Ferguson in fact. Kids used to tell tales about Mr McGhee throwing teacups, cricket balls, anything really, at the wall when he was annoyed. I never witnessed that myself but we were all a bit scared of his reputation, anyway. We had a really good team and used to turn out in this all-green uniform. I was playing soccer with the Cubs as well, which you could only do if you went to church on Sunday. So all the family—me, Mum and Dad and my sisters—made sure we were there every time, without fail.

My parents knew how much I loved soccer. If there was a way for me to get a game, they did everything they could to make it happen. Whether it was playing or getting coaching, I'd have my chance. I was at every soccer school going. The first one was the Roger Morgan Soccer School, run by the former Spurs winger. I went there over and over again, doing all the badges until I got the gold. Dad was a lifelong Manchester United supporter and we started going to watch them when they played in London. My mum's dad was